PRESS INFORMATION BUREAU "2"
GOVERNMENT OF INDIA
****

SMT. GANDHI'S INDEPENDENCE DAY ADDRESS TO THE NATION

New Delhi, Sravana 24, 1903
August 15, 1981

Following is the translation of the Prime Minister, Smt. Indira Gandhi's Address to the Nation, delivered in Hindi from the ramparts of the Red Fort, Delhi on the occasion of the Independence Day:

"Today again is the birthday of Free India. I greet you all. We come here every year to unfurl the flag. This is no ordinary ritual or custom; it is a duty. This is the day when we remember those years when people of all religions, all castes, all languages, all states, rich and poor, women and men, old and young - were all one and united. What was our slogan? - 'we may lose our head but India must become free'. This was our slogan and to achieve this goal we rose from our poverty and from our difficulties. We did not care for the insults and humiliations inflicted on us and put into our freedom struggle all our physical, material and moral resources. How many families were ruined, how many lakhs of people sacrificed their lives and how many jails were filled, that they did not have even enough accommodation. In this Red Fort itself there were prisoners who had passed through the jaws of death. There is no village in India which does not have its own saga of the courage of its brave people. Today we remember all that and pay homage to those

.....2/-

freedom fighters whether they were in our movement of peace and non-violence or whether they adopted other paths. Today we have to tell these old accounts of freedom struggle specially to our younger generation because this was the seed from which the New India is growing up. This plant is still fragile and we have to irrigate it with our sweat and hard labour, and with all the care to make it grow just as we have to plant trees and look after them to make India green all over.

I had spoken from this place a year ago. During this year, like in other years, you have faced many difficulties. Your problems are very well-known to me and I view them not only in my capacity as a Prime Minister but also from the stand-point of a woman and a mother. But if there have been problems and difficulties, and they exist today also, there is no doubt that we have also had successes and achievements. APPLE, which was inaugurated yesterday, is one such achievement. For the first time through this satellite APPLE, not only those who are present here but lakhs of others in different parts of the country are able to participate, listen and watch these today's celebrations. This is not a small achievement for a nation which only a few years back was enmashed in the mire of colonialism.

You may ask that if we can perform such big tasks, for which we are all proud and happy and congratulate our scientists and engineers, then why is it that the other lesser jobs are not done. Why cannot we control prices? This is a moot question.

...3/-

The prices are still high and I know what difficulties
have, pecially my sisters who have to run the homes.
would, however, like to tell you that though prices hav
come down but the rate of increase in prices has certai
been somewhat controlled and step by step this is improv
There are many reasons for rise in prices. One is less
production and we are engaged in increasing it. But anot
reason is, and unfortunately we have such selfish people
our country, and elsewhere also, who try to take advantag
out of such problems. In trying to satisfy their sele
interest, they forget the interest of the country. Hoardi
blackmarketing and profiteering are going on even today,
because those indulge in these anti-social activities had
received encouragement a few years back and have still not
come into our net. Although there has been some impact in
some areas it is still not as much as it should have been.
People demand from us as to why we do not take stern
measures. But if we try to take even slightly stiff
steps then so many obstacles come in the way. Some steps
have been taken and it has had some effect and more such
measures will certainly be taken against the anti-social
elements.

Some shortages occurred because of the nature and
the weather, sometimes even because of our mistakes.
However, all our effort is to increase production. In fact,
agricultural production has gone up. As you all know

...4/-

agricultural production this year has been exceedingly good. You may ask if wheat production has gone up then why we are importing wheat. This is so because we know that here, in the country, an effort is being made by some people to purchase and hoard it and raise prices later. This may cause suffering to many people especially the poorest or those who live in remote areas. This is the reason why at this time, even though we did not need it immediately, and because it was available easily and at low prices abroad and because one should be prepared all the time to face the problems, we took it so that we may protect our people from difficulties.

There has been increase in industrial production also. All our emphasis has been to improve the infrastructure on which depends all production, progress and development, whether of the farmers or of the factories. There has thus been growth in energy, coal and rail transport system though we have not been able to fulfil all that is needed.

In these years, there has been much improvement in social services, like health, education and others. Even then it is not enough and we cannot reach them to the people. Why? Because as these services grow, our population increases at a faster rate. So whatever may be the number of new schools, colleges and universities and howevermany new hospitals and dispensaries

....5/-

be opened, the number of people who need them is always more.

Whether it is a question of inflation or population or other questions, in all these unless there is fullest cooperation from all of you the job cannot be completed. The Government has heavy responsibility and through your vote you have entrusted that responsibility but in a democracy the ordinary citizen also has the same amount of duties. The atmosphere gets vitiated if people are spendthrift and keep on buying things whatever may be the price rise and whether they need a thing or not. I would even say that anyone who acts against the interest of the society in these difficult times acts against the nation. How to check these elements? Laws and rules are made but they cannot always be fully implemented because it is not for the Government alone to implement them. At different levels many people contribute to complete this work and the slightest lapse anywhere can dislocate the entire programme and the policy. We want your cooperation in this also. I do not mean in the least that you take the law in your hands, but it must be emphasised that you should create such an atmosphere in the society that people who want to do wrong things should not be able to prosper, they should be identified and made to feel ashamed before others. If you create such an atmosphere then you will see how quickly the situation can be reformed.

.....6/-

Whatever we may do now, like this purchase of wheat from abroad, some people have raised their voices against it. Who are these people? Who are behind them? Voices are raised by anybody because they are provoked into it by others, but what are the forces behind them. It is they who want that the prices of foodgrains should go up in the market, not that the farmers may get a higher price, because we are ourselves engaged in that effort.

There are many such things which either get stuck in the courts or some other obstacles come in the way, because of which they remain unresolved and delays occur. We have to create a new atmosphere in our society so that everybody may understand what are the duties of an individual. Like I just mentioned about the freedom fighters you are all soldiers for keeping that freedom secure. You have all to involve yourself in this work with the same spirit of sacrifice and service. This is not someone else's work, not of any Government or of any political party only. This is the work of the country, of the common citizens of India, of the poor, of the backward, of the middle class, in fact, of all the people. In the conditions of today some people may earn profits but if the country does not become strong then they will not benefit from profits for long; they will not be able to remain happy for long. We have to keep all these matters in view.

...../-

In today's world, not only in our country but in other countries also, wherever I have visited or where others have gone and have described the situation, we find that there is violence, crime and lawlessness everywhere. We are not concerned with what happens in other countries, although it does influence the situation here. We have to see that we bring about improvement in our own attitudes. We should spread our own humanity and bring about again basic moral values in the society, which is the foundation of all religions, from which, not only we in India, but I think, the entire humanity has taken a wrong turn to a wrong road. With all this wisdom, knowledge and capability, instead of using it for good causes, where is this power being used? We see that big powers are using their resources not in development work, not in helping the poor, but in increasing their armaments - bigger and bigger, and more sophisticated modern weapons. What for? For the annihilation of people or destruction of houses or farms and fields or nations. This is knowingly being done by the human race. Is it the path of India? So, time has come when every Indian must consider this matter in depth and understand his responsibility. Before we tell others anything we have to set things right in our country. In this country where peace used to prevail, where people always lived amicably together, though sometimes small quarrels take place everywhere, but why disturbances take place on a petty matter -

...8/-

sometimes in the name of religion, in the name of caste, sometimes in the name of language? These are the things that come in the way of our progress and development. We must remove these from our path. If there is any cause behind it we have to find it and root it out. We have to create such an atmosphere that no impediment is allowed to come in the way of our development and progress. This is the message of our Independence Day, this year and every year.

We have achieved one stage in our progress, but the journey is still very long. Stockpile of arms is increasing all around us and this is posing increasing danger not only to India but to the entire region and we think, to the whole world. When there is danger everybody suffers but for those who are poor and have shortage of resources, commodities, money or anything else, the burden is more. Therefore, while others have to be vigilant anyway, we Indians have to be more vigilant and alert.

We have to give a new direction to our society. We have to learn many things from our history and heritage. If there are superstitions or other evils we should not have the least hesitation to remove them. We have to develop our own strength. Everyone has his share of problems and difficulties, individuals as well as countries. You all know what I have suffered as a mother, but for me, much bigger is my duty towards you, who are like my children. And that is why these things can hold back neither me nor you. Time waits for none. Our children are growing whether you help them or not. They

.....9

sometimes in the name of religion, in the name of [illegible] sometimes in the name of language? These are the things that come in the way of our progress and development. We have to remove these from our path. If there is any cause behind it we have to find it and root it out. We have to create such an atmosphere that no impediment is allowed to come in the way of our development and progress. This is the message of our Independence Day, this year and every year.

We have achieved one stage in our progress, but the journey is still very long. - Stockpile of arms is increasing all around us and this is posing increasing danger not only to India but to the entire region and we think, to the whole world. When there is danger everybody suffers but for those who are poor and have shortage of resources, commodities, money or anything else, the burden is more. Therefore, while others have to be vigilant anyway, we Indians have to be more vigilant and alert.

We have to give a new direction to our society. We have to learn many things from our history and heritage. If there are superstitions or other evils we should not have the least hesitation to remove them. We have to develop our own strength. Everyone has his share of problems and difficulties, individuals as well as countries. You all know what I have suffered as a mother, but for me, much bigger is my duty towards you, who are like my children. And that is why these things can hold back neither me nor you. Time waits for none. Our children are growing whether you help them or not. The

.....9

and our people's demands are increasing, and rightly so, because if some people are getting things then why not the others, the poor and the backward, also not get those things.

At this time all of us must develop the feelings of unity and strength. We have always made efforts for friendship with our neighbouring countries and others. But when they spurned and attacked us we did face the aggression with courage. And I congratulate and express gratefulness again on your behalf to our jawans and officers of the defence forces for the way in which they kept our borders secure and I know they will continue to do so. But our effort is that there should be no war. And there should be friendship with our neighbours and with far-off countries. Nobody need consider it as our weakness. It is not because of any weakness; we do it for the sake of our ideals. It is our effort that ideals should guide our country should have a life of ideals. It is our policy that all the various regions of the country should progress and develop including the hill regions, the desert areas and the people living in the forests. In the Five-Year Plan there are schemes for everyone- farmers, workers, students, harijans, adivasis, poor people and those belonging to the middle-class. Millions of new opportunities for employment for people will open up and I have confidence that our youth will take full advantage of them. They will also, I am sure, find new avenues for self-employment. It has been our constant effort to push forward schemes for the benefit of the farmers and the workers.

.....10

There was some misunderstanding because recently an Ordinance was issued which prevents strikes in essential public services. I want to assure the workers that this Ordinance is not against them. It has never been our intention and we will never do anything to suppress them or create difficulties for them in any way. But it is necessary that the public services have got to be kept going, not only because it is a government programme but because it is in the interest of the good of the country. These things are required by the common man, and are needed for the strength of the nation and for the security of the nation. Workers have always discharged their responsibilities and I have confidence that they and our farmers our intellectuals and other sections will continue to discharge their responsibilities.

Today is a special day, being Raksha-Bandhan. This is not a religious festival. It is a social festival for cordiality and for friendship. This is the day when people extend their hands of friendship. What for? For protecting each other. On this day we seek the cooperation of all countries in maintaining peace and in protecting the humanity. To our own countrymen, we say that they should celebrate this day not only in the manner of brother-sister relationship but to see how we can protect Mother India; how the unity in the country should be further strengthened and how each individual may consider himself to be the protector of the nation.

.....11

Earlier I had told you about a slogan and at the end I want to say that the flag under which we are standing is not just a piece of cloth. This is a symbol of the sacrifices made in our struggle for freedom, later of the sacrifices by our brave soldiers on our borders in various wars and now of those who with their hard labour are engaged in the struggle for India's progress and also of our promising youth. Our flag and our National Anthem are no ordinary things. They unite the country and bind it together and that is why I want to say that 'the glory of the flag must be protected even at the cost of life'."

UCT:RK:ALP:VPR:KS:GSP:GCD:JML

282/11 15-8-81 1800 HRS.